


**MISSED MANDATE** Congress leaders Priyanka Gandhi and Gaurav Gogoi at the Kamakhya temple ahead of the polls, Guwahati, Feb. 19

ANI

not end before 3 am. He survives on fruit, sprouts, tea and biscuits, and Diet Coke, with one substantial Assamese thali, fish included, around 6 pm. A teetotaller, he recites Bhakti-era saint-scholar Srimanta Sankardev's prayers every morning, reads whenever he has time, and prefers walking and badminton for recreation.

To break gridlocks in governance, he calls multiple secretaries simultaneously rather than letting files get stuck in transit. When a stalemate arose over relocating workers from two dysfunctional central government paper mills that had been sold to private players, he summoned all involved departments and the workers to a single meeting at 5.30 pm and forged a consensus by 6 am. "He has elephantine memory and tracks even minor details with weekly reviews," says a bureaucrat. "If he is sitting in an *adda*, make no mistake, he is gathering information," adds another.

Alongside the state's feedback systems, Sarma has built his own—a direct finger on Assam's pulse. He calls up farmers, tea-garden workers, teachers, students, doctors, civil servants, businessmen, academics and party workers, asking simple questions on a range of issues. He reads almost every WhatsApp message that reaches him. His Cotton College alumni network has produced loyalists across social and political systems and networks.

Sarma's long stint as health minister in the Congress and BJP governments helped him establish the image of a politician who delivers welfare. He expanded access to healthcare by mandating rural service for doctors, increasing medical colleges, adding speciality services and responding quickly to public demands. Later, as education minister, he introduced transparent recruitment examinations for teachers, giving thousands of young people confidence that jobs could be secured on merit.

None of this would matter politically without the other face of the machine: his willingness to fight without retreat. "People appreciate brave and decisive leaders," Sarma says. "I have always taken bold decisions at critical moments." In 2010, when the Tarun Gogoi government came under attack from activists over big dams, Sarma, then a minister, took the front line in its defence. When the Sarbananda Sonowal government was cornered over the Citizenship (Amendment) Act in 2020, he moved forward again. During COVID-19, while most public figures sheltered, Sarma, as health minister, entered hospitals and isolation wards in PPE, inspecting facilities and interacting with patients.

**Sarma delivered fast-paced development. Rural roads lengthened. Bridges and flyovers came up. A semiconductor unit came to the state. Over 100,000 govt jobs were delivered**

But when cornered, Sarma also has the skill to shift the narrative rather than be left defending dodgy turf. The death of singer Zubeen Garg in Singapore in September 2025 could have been a political grenade. Singapore's coroner ruled it an accidental drowning; Opposition leaders focused the heat lamp on event manager Shyamkanu Mahanta. It had political bite: the Mahantas were not strangers to Sarma's corridors. Shyam-